



Gaping jaws swallow prey nearly half fish's own size

Traps and tricks

Instead of chasing their food, the animal world's most specialized hunters use traps to catch their prey. Trappers work in all types of habitat, from the soil to the deep sea. Spiders and ant lions build their lairs themselves, but some predators have body parts that act as lures—attracting unsuspecting victims toward their jaws. A few hunters even use bait to bring their prey within reach.

Fatal lights

In the permanent darkness of the ocean depths, many predators hunt by trailing luminous lures.

This scaly dragonfish has a glowing whisker, called a bioluminescent barbel, which hangs from its jaws and attracts smaller fish toward its mouth. Some deep-sea fish use bioluminescent bacteria to make their light, but the dragonfish creates its own, using a light-emitting chemical called luciferin. Its prey are often luminous as well, so the dragonfish has a black stomach lining to stop other predators from homing in on fish that it has swallowed.

Bioluminescent barbel produces steady light, which attracts prey



Deadly doors

Unlike web-making spiders, a trapdoor spider hunts by ambushing its prey on the ground. It builds a tunnel equipped with a hinged lid made from silk and particles of soil. The spider then waits hidden at the top of its burrow, with the door slightly ajar. If an insect walks past, the spider feels the vibrations and immediately reacts. In a split second, it throws open the door, grabs its prey, and then pulls it underground. After slamming the door shut, the spider starts to feed.